50TH ANNIVERSARY

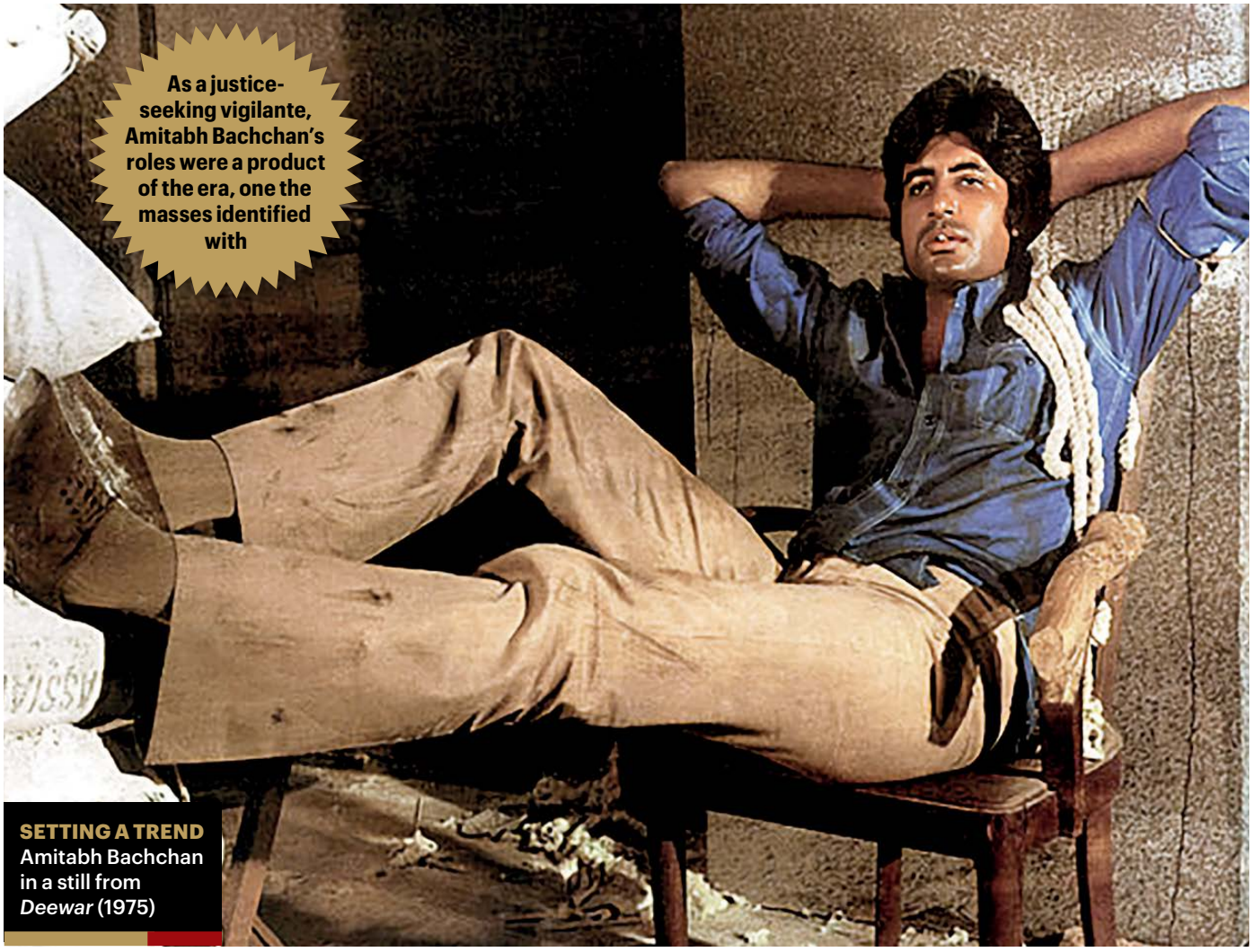
ENTERTAINMENT
1975-1985

The Rise of the Angry Hero

Anger—at injustice and inequality—spilled out on to streets and into gritty films. Its unlikely mascot? A lanky, unconventionally handsome man they often called 'Vijay'

India was angry in the 1970s. The euphoria of freedom had faded; liberalisation wasn't here yet. The nation's pent-up frustration found its way to celluloid, that accurate barometer of the zeitgeist. Indian films lost their playful innocence and became grittier and grounded, portraying a not-so-rosy reality. Our collective angst, fuelled by inequality and systemic corruption, found an unlikely mascot—a gangly man who did not fit any of the conventional stereotypes of a matinee idol. As the justice-seeking, anti-establishment hero, Amitabh Bachchan was a product of the era, even as he embodied it, someone the masses could readily identify with.

The origin of the 'angry young man' archetype can be traced to Prakash



As a justice-seeking vigilante, Amitabh Bachchan's roles were a product of the era, one the masses identified with

SETTING A TREND Amitabh Bachchan in a still from *Deewar* (1975)